

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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D

The Dangers of Sin

Choosing sin instead of remaining faithful to the one true God leads to disaster. This has been true since the beginning, when Adam and Eve's disobedience brought curses and separation from their first home ([Genesis 3](#)). It was also true throughout Israel's history (see, for example, [Numbers 16](#); [Joshua 7](#); [2 Samuel 11:1-12:19](#)). The New Testament gives many warnings about the eternal consequences of not repenting for sinful behavior ([1 Corinthians 6:9-10](#); [Galatians 5:19-21](#); [Revelation 22:15](#)).

During the late period of the Israelite kingdom, God's people often committed sinful acts. Words like sin and evil frequently describe the kings of Israel ([2 Kings 3:2](#); [13:2](#), [11](#); [14:24](#); [15:9](#), [18](#), [24](#), [28](#); [17:2](#)). This was true about the kings of Judah as well. They "did evil in the sight of the LORD" ([8:18](#), [27](#); [21:2](#), [16](#), [20](#); [23:32](#), [37](#); [24:9](#), [19](#)).

The northern kingdom of Israel was especially guilty. The Scriptures consistently criticize the kings and people for their lack of faith ([2 Kings 17:16-17](#), [22](#)). The main sin of false worship, started by Jeroboam I, continued in Israel until the end ([10:29](#); [17:21-23](#); [23:15](#)). God gave repeated warnings to the people through his prophets ([17:13](#)). He allowed foreign invaders to punish them ([13:3](#), [7](#)).

The Israelites did not change their behavior ([13:6](#); [17:14-17](#)). Eventually, God let foreign invaders defeat them and capture their land. The Assyrians took many people away into exile ([17:18](#), [20-23](#)).

The people of Judah were not innocent either. Many of their kings were guilty of serious evil. Judean society became more rebellious, and "lived according to the customs Israel had introduced" ([2 Kings 17:19](#)). But God showed repeated kindness (for example, [19:32-36](#)). His prophets warned the people ([21:8-15](#)). Yet, the people continued to sin, and God judged them again ([21:10-15](#); [23:26-27](#); [24:1-4](#); [25:1-21](#)).

When people truly repent, God will graciously forgive them and remove sin's penalty. Yet, it is better to remain faithful to God's commands ([2 Kings 18:5-6](#); [23:25](#); [Psalm 119:9-11](#), [33-37](#); [2 Timothy 4:7](#); [Revelation 2:10](#)). Then God's blessings can lead to success ([Psalm 112:1](#); [119:1-2](#); [144:15](#); [2 Kings 18:7](#); see also [2 Chronicles 26:4-5](#); [Proverbs 3:1-10](#); [2 Corinthians 3:5](#)). God's people should give God priority in their lives ([1 Kings 18:21](#), [36-39](#); see [Deuteronomy 6:13](#); [10:12-13](#); [Micah 6:8](#); [Matthew 6:33](#)). They should pray for God's endur-

ing grace ([Psalm 19:13](#)). They should let the word of God guide them ([Psalm 119:9](#); [Colossians 3:16](#); [2 Timothy 3:16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 18:20-21](#);
[Exodus 34:7](#); [Leviticus 26:14-46](#); [Numbers 15:30-31](#);
[Deuteronomy 31:16-18](#); [1 Kings 8:46-51](#); [2 Kings 8:18](#),
[27](#); [2 Kings 13:1-7](#); [14:23-24](#); [17:13-23](#); [18:9-12](#); [21:8-16](#);
[23:25-27](#); [24:1-3](#), [19-25:21](#); [2 Chronicles 7:14](#); [33:12-13](#);
[Psalm 119:9-11](#), [33-37](#); [Jeremiah 44:2-6](#); [Micah 6:8](#);
[Matthew 6:33](#); [Colossians 3:16](#); [2 Timothy 3:16](#); [4:7](#);
[Revelation 2:10](#)

Darkness and Light

Darkness

Darkness means there is no light. There was no light until God commanded it to appear. He then separated light from darkness ([Genesis 1:2](#), [4-5](#), [18](#)). The ninth plague he sent against Egypt was three days of deep darkness, with no light at all ([Exodus 10:21-23](#)).

Darkness surrounds God ([Exodus 20:21](#); [Deuteronomy 4:11](#); [5:23](#); [2 Samuel 22:12](#); [Psalm 18:11](#); [97:2](#)). He lives in thick darkness ([1 Kings 8:12](#) and the parallel passage in [2 Chronicles 6:1](#)). Thick darkness is beneath his feet ([2 Samuel 22:10](#) and the parallel passage in [Psalm 18:9](#)). We cannot know God unless he reveals himself.

Darkness often represents distress and anxiety. Or it can refer to the confusion and destruction experienced by the evil people ([Genesis 15:12](#); [Job 12:25](#); [19:8](#); [Psalms 35:6](#); [107:10](#), [14](#); [Ecclesiastes 5:17](#); [Isaiah 5:30](#)).

For Job, darkness meant emptiness ([Job 3:4-6](#)). It symbolized death, a land of shadow and gloom where the dead live, far from daylight ([Job 10:21-22](#); [17:12-13](#); [Ecclesiastes 6:4](#)).

Evil often happens in the dark ([Job 24:16-17](#)). But darkness cannot hide anything from God ([Psalm 139:11-12](#); [Isaiah 29:15-16](#)). Darkness often represents not knowing God's will. Knowing God is "light," so not knowing is "darkness" ([Job 12:24-25](#); [Matthew 4:16](#); [John 1:5](#); [8:12](#); [12:35](#), [46](#); [1 John 1:5](#); [2:8-9](#), [11](#)).

The Bible often uses "darkness" to describe a sinful or evil way of life ([Proverbs 2:13](#); [4:19](#); [Isaiah 5:20](#); [60:2](#)). In the New Testament, darkness can also represent living without the truth of God ([Matthew 6:23](#); [Luke 11:35](#); [Romans 2:19](#); [Colossians 1:13](#)). [Isaiah 9:2](#) speaks of a people living in distress who see a great light (see also [Matthew 4:16](#); [Luke 1:79](#)). This light is Jesus himself. In

that context, “darkness” refers more to suffering and need than to spiritual ignorance.

A major theme of the Old Testament prophets was the “Day of the LORD,” often linked with darkness ([Ezekiel 32:8](#); [Joel 2:2, 31](#); [Amos 5:18, 20](#); [Zephaniah 1:15](#)). The New Testament also connects darkness with judgment ([Matthew 8:12](#); [22:13](#); [25:30](#); [2 Peter 2:17](#); [Jude 1:6, 13](#)).

Light

Light was the first thing God created after the heavens and earth ([Genesis 1:3](#); see also [1:16](#)). It naturally symbolizes what is pleasant, good, or cheerful ([Ecclesiastes 11:7](#); [James 1:17](#)). When the Israelites left Egypt, a pillar of cloud and fire gave them light ([Exodus 13:21](#); [14:20](#)). It showed them the way ([Nehemiah 9:19](#)). Light represents the Lord's blessing ([Job 12:22](#); [29:2-3](#); [Psalms 4:6](#); [18:28](#); [44:3](#); [118:27](#)). God's servants can share this blessing by guiding others to God through their obedience ([Isaiah 42:6](#); [49:6](#)). God's light also reveals sin and brings justice ([Psalms 90:8](#); [Isaiah 51:4](#)).

The Bible describes God as light ([Psalm 27:1](#); [Isaiah 60:19-20](#); [Daniel 2:22](#); [1 John 1:5](#)). He “dwells in unapproachable light” (see [1 Timothy 6:16](#)). Yet, he guides his followers into the light ([Micah 7:8-9](#); see also [1 John 1:7](#)).

Jesus said, “I am the light of the world” ([John 8:12](#); [9:5](#); [12:46](#)). He brought a message from God, but he was also that message ([John 1:1-10](#)). Those who receive his message and trust in him, He gives “the right to become children of God” ([John 1:9-12](#)). His light spiritually enlightens them and they come to know God and his salvation ([Matthew 4:16](#); [Luke 2:32](#); [Acts 13:47](#); [26:18](#)).

They are “sons of light” ([John 12:36](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:5](#)). They “walk in the light” ([1 John 1:7](#)). Their actions are like light—by doing what is good and right and true ([Ephesians 5:8-9](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:3-5, 14-18](#); [15:12](#); [Exodus 10:21-23](#); [14:20](#); [20:21](#); [2 Samuel 22:10-13](#); [1 Kings 8:12](#); [Job 3:3-7](#); [12:22-25](#); [15:22](#); [17:12-13](#); [34:22](#); [Psalms 18:11, 28](#); [27:1](#); [97:2-6](#); [139:11-12](#); [Proverbs 2:13](#); [4:18-19](#); [Ecclesiastes 11:7-8](#); [Isaiah 5:20](#); [9:2](#); [29:15](#); [51:4](#); [60:2-3](#), [19-20](#); [Daniel 2:22](#); [Micah 7:8-9](#); [Matthew 4:16](#); [6:22-23](#); [8:12](#); [Luke 1:78-79](#); [2:32](#); [John 1:4-9](#); [8:12](#); [9:5](#); [12:35-36](#), [46](#); [Acts 13:47](#); [26:18](#); [Romans 2:19-20](#); [Ephesians 5:7-14](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:5-8](#); [1 Timothy 6:16](#); [James 1:17](#); [2 Peter 2:17](#); [1 John 1:5-7](#); [2:7-11](#)

David's Response to Unfriendly Leaders

As David became successful, King Saul became his enemy. The Lord rejected Saul because of the king's unfaithfulness, and the Holy Spirit's anointing then rested on David ([1 Samuel 15:1-16:14](#)). When Saul needed someone to calm his mind, David's harp playing soothed him ([16:15-23](#)). When Saul needed someone to encounter the threat of Goliath, David proved to be a capable and successful young warrior ([1 Samuel 17](#)). As others noticed David and praised his success, Saul became frightened and jealous ([18:6-9](#)). His jealousy soon became anger, rage, and murderous hatred.

After King Saul tried to kill David with a spear twice ([1 Samuel 18:10-11](#)), David kept serving him. He led a group of the king's troops ([18:13](#)). He married the king's daughter ([18:17-27](#)). He played the harp in Saul's royal court ([19:7, 9](#)). David kept succeeding in everything he did. This made Saul very fearful and suspicious, and he tried to kill David again ([19:9-11](#)). David had to escape to save his life ([19:11-18](#); [20:1-42](#)).

For the rest of King Saul's rule, David was a fugitive, hunted by the king he had loyally served. Even then, he refused to harm Saul. On two occasions, David had the chance to kill Saul ([1 Samuel 24:1-22](#); [26:1-25](#)). But he refused to attack “the LORD's anointed” ([24:6](#); [26:9](#)).

During these years as a fugitive, David continued to serve the Lord and the people of Israel ([1 Samuel 23:1-6](#); [25:4-9, 14-16](#); [27:8-9](#)). When David heard that Saul and Jonathan had died, he mourned deeply for the “beloved and delightful” king and his son ([2 Samuel 1:17-27](#)).

David remained loyal to a king who hated him and wanted him dead. In a similar way, the prophet Jeremiah wrote a prophesy in the royal court where they burned it and put him in a cistern to die ([Jeremiah 36:21-26](#); [38:1-13](#)). The prophet Daniel and his friends also faithfully served in the royal courts of Babylonian and Persian. They did this even though the kings made decisions against their faith or them personally ([Daniel 3:1-30](#); [6:1-28](#)).

Being faithful under an enemy's rule does not always lead to success. Jesus is the ultimate example. The Jewish authorities pursued him and eventually had him killed. Jesus did not achieve worldly success, but he trusted his Father in heaven. His success came after death in the resurrection.

We might also die while living under leaders who are against us, and we might not see any good results from our suffering. But in the future world that God will bring, he will fix everything that was wrong. God

will reward those who remain faithful even when they suffer under cruel leaders.

Passages for Further Study

1 Samuel 24:1–22; 2 Samuel 1:1–27; 11:1–27;
Jeremiah 36:21–27; 38:1–13; Daniel 3:1–30; 6:1–28;
John 8:29; Philippians 2:6–11; Hebrews 5:7–10;
1 Peter 2:13–3:7

The Day Is Coming

Jesus prophesied three future events in the Synoptic Gospels:

1. One event was his own death and resurrection (Mark 8:31; 9:31; 10:33–34). This had already happened before the Gospels were written.
2. The second event Jesus prophesied was the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 (Matthew 24:1–28; 13:1–23; Luke 19:41–44; 21:5–24). This event was probably about to happen when Mark wrote his Gospel (see Mark Book Introduction, “Date”). Yet, this event would not mark the absolute end. So the Christian community must continue to live faithfully and be spiritually watching for the return of the Son of God in glory, which could be soon (Mark 13:34–37).
3. The third event Jesus prophesied was his own future return (Matthew 23:39; 24:3, 29–31, 24:36–25:46; Mark 8:38; 13:24–27, 32–37; Luke 21:25–36; John 14:1–3). The New Testament frequently mentions Jesus’ second coming (see, for example, 1 Corinthians 1:7–8; 3:13; 5:5; 2 Corinthians 1:14; Philippians 1:6, 10; 2:16; 1 Thessalonians 5:1–11; 2 Thessalonians 2:2; 2 Timothy 1:12, 18; 4:1, 8).

When Jesus returns, God’s kingdom promises will come true. Jesus will judge and destroy Satan and his angels (Romans 16:20; 2 Thessalonians 2:3–12). Those who refuse to trust in Jesus will experience eternal judgment (Matthew 13:40–42; 25:31–46; Luke 6:24–26; 16:19–31; Acts 10:42; Ephesians 5:6; Colossians 3:6; Hebrews 10:25; 2 Peter 3:7; Jude 1:6; Revelation 1:7; 6:14, 17). Meanwhile, the faithful will resurrect to enjoy eternal life (1 Thessalonians 4:13–18). God will gather his chosen people for salvation (Mark 13:27; Hebrews 1:14; 9:27–28), grace (1 Peter 1:13), and glory (1 Thessalonians 2:12; 2 Thessalonians 2:14; 1 Peter 1:7; 5:1, 4).

He will give his people an endless inheritance and new eternal bodies (1 Peter 1:4; 1 Corinthians 15:35–57; Philippians 3:21; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18). God will free all of creation from its curse and transform it (Genesis 3:17–18; Romans 8:20–23; 2 Peter 3:12–13; Revelation 21:1–22:5). Sorrow, tears, mourning, and

death will no longer exist (Revelation 21:4). Those who were faithful to Christ in this life “will see God” (Matthew 5:8; Revelation 22:3).

Because of these promises, Christians must pray and wait for his return (Matthew 6:10; Revelation 22:20). We must not try to guess the dates of his coming (Mark 13:32; Acts 1:7). Instead, we must live honorably and stay prepared (1 John 2:28; Matthew 24:36–25:30; 1 Thessalonians 5:1–11).

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 5:8; 6:10; 13:41–42; 23:39; 24:3–25:46;
Mark 8:38; 13:1–37; 14:25; Luke 6:24–26; 16:19–31;
19:41–44; 21:5–36; John 14:1–3; Acts 1:6–7; 10:42;
Romans 8:20–23; 16:20; 1 Corinthians 1:7–8; 15:35–58;
2 Corinthians 1:14; Philippians 1:6, 10; 2:16;
3:21; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18; 2 Thessalonians 2:2–14;
2 Timothy 4:1–8; Titus 2:11–13; Hebrews 9:28; 10:25,
37; 1 Peter 1:7, 13; 5:1–4; 2 Peter 3:7–13; 1 John 2:28;
Revelation 1:7; 6:15–17; 21:1–22:7; 22:12, 20

The Day of the Lord

The phrase day of the Lord describes a time when God judges his enemies with righteous punishment. The ungodly receive the punishment they deserve, while the righteous gain their complete salvation (see Isaiah 3:16–4:6). On this day, God shows his powerful control over creation. When God appears in glory, people feel fear (2:10, 19, 21). This is because he examines all human support systems. This includes religious, economic, military, and social structures.

This phrase first appears in the prophecy of Amos (Amos 5:18). But it did not start with him. Amos corrected a common misunderstanding among the Israelites. They thought the day of the Lord would be a joyful day of salvation. They believed God would judge Israel’s enemies and restore Israelite rule over greater Canaan.

Yet, Amos warned that the day of the Lord would bring darkness, not light. This was because the people were rebelling against God (see Amos 5:10–12, 21–27). The Israelites were confident that God was always on their side. But their sins made them God’s enemies, deserving full punishment.

The prophets often used the phrase “that day” to describe an important event (see Isaiah 2:11; 27:1; Zephaniah 1:8). Because of God’s warnings and the people’s sins, the prophets saw “that day” as near (see Joel 1:15; 2:1). They hoped their warnings would cause God’s people to repent (see Zephaniah 2:1–3). Unfortunately, most people ignored these warnings.

The day of the Lord arrived for the northern kingdom when Assyria destroyed Samaria. It came for the southern kingdom when Babylon invaded and destroyed Jerusalem between 605 and 586 BC.

The day of the Lord is disastrous for ungodly people. The prophet Joel compares its destruction to a locust plague ([Joel 1:1-2:11](#)). Yet, this day guarantees God's people that he is sovereign and just. It is a day of salvation for those who obey the prophets and "everyone who calls on the name of the LORD" (see [Joel 2:31-32](#)).

The same God who brings destruction to his enemies will be a refuge and stronghold for his people ([Joel 3:16](#)). Nations used by God to judge Israel and Judah will later experience their own "day of the Lord" (see, for example, [Isaiah 13:4-22](#); [Ezekiel 30:1-5](#); [Obadiah 1:15-16](#)).

The Old Testament prophets mostly regarded judgment as happening during the exile of the Israelites to Babylon. New Testament writers use the phrase day of the Lord to describe the return of Jesus as the judge of the world. That day "will come like a thief" ([2 Peter 3:10](#); see also [1 Thessalonians 5:2-4](#)). Therefore, God's people must be ready, or they will experience an end similar to those who ignored the prophets' warnings.

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 2:10-22](#); [4:1-6](#); [13:4-12](#); [Ezekiel 30:1-5](#); [Joel 1:13-15](#); [2:1-11](#), [28-32](#); [3:9-16](#); [Amos 5:18-24](#); [Obadiah 1:15-16](#); [Zephaniah 1:2-18](#); [Malachi 4:1-5](#); [1 Corinthians 1:8](#); [5:5](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:2](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:2](#); [2 Timothy 1:18](#); [2 Peter 3:10](#); [Revelation 20:1-15](#)

Dealing with Conflict

God's people often experience conflict. It either comes from those outside of God's people who are against God. Or it comes from those within God's people who cause trouble. Dealing with conflict needs wisdom and care, since small issues can become big problems.

Paul encountered opposition from the government and community leaders ([Acts 16:22-24](#); [Acts 19:23-34](#)). Moses dealt with the complaining and unhappy people of Israel (for example, [Exodus 17:1-4](#)). The book of Nehemiah offers a detailed example of how a godly person can deal with conflict.

Nehemiah

Nehemiah experienced challenges both from those outside and those within God's people as he followed God's guidance.

External Conflict

Foreigners like Sanballat, Geshem, and Tobiah strongly opposed rebuilding Jerusalem's walls and mocked Nehemiah's leadership ([Nehemiah 2:10](#), [2:19](#); [4:1-3](#)). The opposition increased to include Arabs, Ammonites, and people from Ashdod, who planned to attack the builders ([4:7-9](#), [11](#)).

To counter this, Nehemiah set up guards, prayed for God's help, created an emergency alert system, and continued working ([4:6-23](#)). Israel's frustrated enemies tried several times to disgrace or kill Nehemiah ([6:1-14](#)). Yet, Nehemiah wisely avoided or stopped their plans while staying focused on his mission from God.

Internal Conflict

Nehemiah also encountered problems within God's people. Wealthy Jews were mistreating the poor by charging high interest ([5:1-13](#)). Jews had married foreigners who worshiped other gods ([13:23-30](#)). Many did not give tithes or honor the Sabbath day ([10:31-39](#); [13:10-22](#)). Finally, Nehemiah had to oppose the priest Eliashib, who had allowed Tobiah to use one of the temple storerooms ([13:4-9](#)).

Confronting these problems required a firm commitment to the principles in Scripture. He had to be bold by insisting that people follow these divine instructions. He needed to show compassion in restoring people to fellowship after the confrontation.

In each case, Nehemiah bravely followed the example of earlier leaders. Moses opposed the worship of the golden calf ([Exodus 32](#)). The prophet Samuel opposed those involved in Baal worship ([1 Samuel 7:3-8](#)). The prophet Nathan confronted David when he sinned ([2 Samuel 12:1-14](#)). King Jehoshaphat trusted God to defeat a stronger enemy ([2 Chronicles 20:1-37](#)).

Like these earlier men of God, Nehemiah defended what was right. He did not let those he led do what they wanted. He refused to become discouraged or intimidated by internal problems or external threats. He consistently relied on God for wisdom and blessings for his work.

Jesus and the Apostle Paul

Jesus and the apostle Paul both provided strategies for dealing with internal conflict ([Matthew 5:23-26](#); [18:15-17](#); [1 Corinthians 6:1-8](#); [10:23-33](#)). They also strategized how to deal with external conflict ([Matthew 5:43-47](#); [Romans 12:14-21](#)). Unfortunately, the actions of Christians, no matter how good, may still encounter continued or increased opposition. The Bible encourages us deal with opposition like Nehemiah. We must use wisdom, patience, prayer, and determination.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 13:5–13; 26:12–35; Exodus 32:1–35;
 1 Samuel 7:3–8; 2 Samuel 12:1–31; 19:41–43;
 2 Chronicles 20:1–37; 34:3–7; Nehemiah 2:19–20; 4:1–23;
 5:1–13; 6:1–14; 13:4–28; Psalm 140:1–2; Proverbs 13:10;
 17:14, 19; 25:8; 26:17, 21; 29:22; Habakkuk 1:3;
 Acts 23:6–11; 2 Corinthians 7:5–6; Ephesians 6:10–18;
 Philippians 2:3; 1 Timothy 6:4; 2 Timothy 2:14, 23–26;
 Titus 2:15; James 3:13–18

Death

Humans are mortal, and death is the natural end of life on earth (Psalm 90:1–6). Human identity began when God breathed life into the dust of the earth and made a man (Genesis 2:7). This state reverses at death when God takes back his breath. Then the human body returns to dust (3:19; Job 4:19–21; Isaiah 40:6–8). Human life fully depends on the creator. His breath is a gift that sustains us as long as he allows (Psalm 104:29).

Sin brought death into human life and caused much harm. Death often comes without warning, making people feel very sad. When someone dies, it can feel like their hopes and plans for the future have ended. The death penalty is the strongest punishment that human courts can give. In the Old Testament, the death penalty was for crimes such as murder or blasphemy (Genesis 9:6; Exodus 21:12; Leviticus 24:16; John 10:30–33). These were crimes that endangered the community.

In the Old Testament, Sheol is the opposite of “the land of the living” (Psalm 27:13). This is the dark and silent place where dead people are (Job 10:21–22; Psalm 94:17; Jonah 2:6). Even in death, God’s people have hope (see Proverbs 14:32). God is sovereign (in complete control) and rules over death (Deuteronomy 32:39).

The Old Testament often describes death as joining one’s ancestors, without mentioning resurrection (see, for example, Genesis 49:29–33). Yet, there are some hints of resurrection (see Job 19:25–27; Isaiah 25:6–9; 26:19; Daniel 12:2). Jewish belief in resurrection became more common during the period between the Old and New Testaments.

Resurrection is a key theme in the New Testament. Through Christ, God’s redeemed people will overcome death. Death is the last enemy God destroys (1 Corinthians 15:54–57, 26). Death comes from sin (Romans 5:12). Those who live in a sinful state and do not repent (turn away from sin) will experience punishment in the lake of fire, known as “the second death” (Revelation 21:8).

But Jesus’ death defeated death. When Jesus died and rose again, he showed that death is not the final authority over humanity. His resurrection is a model for all Christians (Colossians 1:18). He is “the Lord of both the living and the dead” (Romans 14:9). When someone dies, it is natural to mourn. But it should also be a time to show great trust in God. Those who receive God’s promises have hope that they will live after the grave.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 2:15–17; 3:19; 6:17; 9:5–6; 49:29–33;
 Exodus 21:12–17, 28–29; 23:7; 31:14–15;
 Leviticus 24:16; Deuteronomy 32:39; Job 10:18–22;
 19:25–27; Psalms 90:1–12; 94:17; Proverbs 14:32;
 Ecclesiastes 12:1–7; Isaiah 25:6–9; 26:19; 40:6–8;
 Daniel 12:2–3; Mark 12:26–27; Romans 5:12–17;
 1 Corinthians 15:20–26, 51–58; Revelation 20:4–6, 11–15;
 21:3–8

Divine Sovereignty and Human Responsibility

The Bible shows that everything is under God’s control. In other words, God is sovereign over everything. For example, rain falls on both good and bad people as part of God’s plan (Matthew 5:45).

God is not responsible for our sins. They come from our own desires so we are responsible for them. Scripture shows that people can choose to follow God or reject him (see, for example, Deuteronomy 30:1–20; Joshua 24:15; John 1:12; Romans 10:9–13). God does not force people to have faith in him.

Ezekiel 14:9–11 describes an interesting situation where God deceives a prophet but still holds the prophet responsible for his actions. This raises a challenging question: How do we explain how God is in control of everything but humans make personal choices for which we are accountable?

When God allowed false prophets to tell untrue messages, he gave them and their listeners what they wanted (see 2 Thessalonians 2:11). Even a false prophet could only mislead people with the Lord’s permission or guidance. Without God’s restraint, they would choose lies over truth and worship “the creature rather than the Creator” (see Romans 1:18–25). God allowed them to follow their sinful desires.

The amazing thing is not that God lets some sinners stay in their false beliefs. But it is amazing that he saves sinners. He changes their desires so they want to do good for his glory (see Ezekiel 36:25–26; Romans 8:1–11; Ephesians 2:10). We cannot fully un-

derstand this difficult issue. Yet, we can be sure of God's freely given grace. We can have hope in the new life he offers through his Holy Spirit to all who trust in him.

Passages for Further Study

1 Samuel 2:6-7; 1 Kings 22:19-22; 2 Chronicles 20:6; Job 1:8-12; 2:2-6; Psalms 115:3; 135:6-14; Isaiah 45:6-7; Lamentations 3:37-40; Ezekiel 14:9-11; 17:24; 36:25-26; Daniel 2:20-22; Amos 3:6; 4:6-11; Romans 1:18-25; 9:8-33; 12:2; Ephesians 4:20-24; 2 Thessalonians 2:11-12; Hebrews 13:20-21; James 1:13-14; 4:12-16